



(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

Cancer

Cancer is a condition where cells in the body grow in an uncontrolled way. Speak to a GP if you notice any symptoms that are not normal for you.

Possible symptoms of cancer

Different types of cancer all have their own symptoms.

General symptoms which could be a sign of cancer can include:

- a new lump or swelling anywhere on your body
- sweating a lot (particularly at night) or a high temperature that lasts a long time or keeps coming back
- feeling more tired than usual
- unusual bruising or bleeding (such as bleeding from your bottom, blood in your pee or vomiting blood)
- pain anywhere in your body that's not usual for you
- losing weight without trying or feeling less hungry than usual
- needing to pee more often or more urgently, or pain when you pee

Other symptoms of cancer may affect specific parts of the body.

Symptoms affecting your skin

Skin symptoms can include:

- a new mole, or changes to a mole anywhere on your body
- changes in your skin, such as a rash or sore that does not get better
- the whites of your eyes or your skin looking yellow (jaundice) – yellow skin may be harder to see on black or brown skin

Symptoms affecting your digestion

Digestion symptoms can include:

- heartburn or indigestion that's frequent, very painful or gets worse
- a swollen tummy (bloating) that happens often or lasts a long time
- changes in your poo, such as needing to poo more or less often than usual, diarrhoea or constipation that does not get better or gets worse

Symptoms affecting your mouth or throat

Mouth and throat symptoms can include:

- problems swallowing

- a hoarse or croaky voice that does not get better
- a sore or ulcer in your mouth that does not get better
- white or red patches in your mouth

Symptoms affecting your lungs and breathing

Lung and breathing symptoms can include:

- a cough that does not get better or gets worse
- shortness of breath that does not get better or gets worse
- coughing up blood

Symptoms affecting your genitals (vagina or penis)

Vagina or penis symptoms can include:

- vaginal discharge that's not usual for you
- unusual vaginal bleeding, such as bleeding between periods or after sex, or bleeding after the menopause
- difficulty getting an erection
- blood in your semen

See a GP if you have:

- symptoms of cancer
- any symptoms or changes that are not normal for you and you're worried could be cancer

If a GP thinks your symptoms could be a sign of cancer, you may get an urgent referral for more tests or to see a specialist in hospital.

Important

Most of these symptoms are very common and can be caused by other conditions.

Having these symptoms does not definitely mean you have cancer, but it's important to get checked by a GP.

If your symptoms are caused by cancer, finding it early may mean it's easier to treat.

Possible causes of cancer

Anyone can get cancer and it's not always clear what causes it. But there are things that can increase your risk of getting certain types of cancer.

These can include:

- getting older
- other people in your family having certain cancers
- your lifestyle – such as smoking, being overweight, exposure to too much sun and drinking too much alcohol
- having certain viruses – such as human papillomavirus (HPV) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/human-papilloma-virus-hpv/) or hepatitis
- having certain conditions – such as severe acid reflux or Lynch syndrome (a condition that runs in families)
- the environment where you work or live – such as exposure to asbestos or air pollution

Reducing your risk of cancer

You cannot always prevent cancer, but there are things you can do to reduce your risk of getting some types of cancer.

Do

- ✓ have cancer screening when you're invited – such as cervical screening (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/cervical-screening/), breast screening (mammogram) (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/breast-screening-mammogram/) or bowel cancer screening (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/bowel-cancer-screening/)
- ✓ have the HPV vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/hpv-vaccine/) or hepatitis B vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/hepatitis-b-vaccine/) if you're offered them
- ✓ speak to a GP about genetic testing for cancer risk genes (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/genetic-tests-for-cancer-risk/) if a type of cancer runs in your family, a relative has been told they have a faulty gene linked to cancer, or you have 1 or more Jewish grandparents
- ✓ try to cut down on alcohol (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/alcohol-advice/tips-on-cutting-down-alcohol/) and avoid drinking more than 14 units a week
- ✓ try to lose weight (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/healthy-weight/managing-your-weight/tips-to-help-you-lose-weight/) if you're overweight, or keep to a healthy weight
- ✓ try to quit smoking (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/quit-smoking/)
- ✓ follow advice on sunscreen and sun safety (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/seasonal-health/sunscreen-and-sun-safety/), such as wearing sunscreen of at least 30 SPF and spending time in the shade, to protect your skin
- ✓ eat a balanced diet (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/eat-well/how-to-eat-a-balanced-diet/eating-a-balanced-diet/)
- ✓ be physically active (Link: www.nhs.uk/live-well/exercise/physical-activity-guidelines-for-adults-aged-19-to-64/) – aim for at least 150 minutes of moderate activity or 75 minutes of vigorous activity a week

Find out more from NHS Better Health

NHS Better Health has free tools and support to help you lose weight, get active, quit smoking and drink less alcohol.

Visit the NHS Better Health website (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/better-health/>)

Types of cancer

There are more than 200 different types of cancer.

Cancer can affect any part of your body, including your organs, blood, bone marrow and immune system.

Sometimes cancer spreads from one place to another. This is called secondary cancer, or metastasis.

▼ Show possible types of cancer

Blood, bones or bone marrow

- Acute lymphoblastic leukaemia (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/acute-lymphoblastic-leukaemia/)
- Acute myeloid leukaemia (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/acute-myeloid-leukaemia/)
- Bone cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/bone-cancer/)
- Chronic lymphocytic leukaemia (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/chronic-lymphocytic-leukaemia/)
- Chronic myeloid leukaemia (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/chronic-myeloid-leukaemia/)
- Multiple myeloma (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/multiple-myeloma/)
- Myelodysplastic syndrome (myelodysplasia) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/myelodysplasia/)

Breasts and chest

- Breast cancer in women (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/breast-cancer-in-women/)
- Breast cancer in men (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/breast-cancer-in-men/)
- Lung cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/lung-cancer/)

Tummy and digestive system

- Anal cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/anal-cancer/)
- Bile duct cancer (cholangiocarcinoma) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/bile-duct-cancer/) – affects small tubes that connect different organs in the digestive system (bile ducts)
- Bladder cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/bladder-cancer/)
- Bowel cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/bowel-cancer/)
- Gallbladder cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/gallbladder-cancer/) – affects a small organ in the top part of your tummy that helps you digest your food (gallbladder)
- Kidney cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/kidney-cancer/)
- Liver cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/liver-cancer/)
- Oesophageal cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/oesophageal-cancer/) – affects the oesophagus, sometimes called the gullet or food pipe
- Pancreatic cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/pancreatic-cancer/)
- Stomach cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/stomach-cancer/)

Head, neck and throat

- Brain cancer (malignant brain tumour) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/malignant-brain-tumour/)
- Eye cancer (ocular cancer) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/eye-cancer/)
- Laryngeal cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/laryngeal-cancer/) – affects the voice box (larynx)
- Mouth cancer (oral cancer) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/mouth-cancer/)
- Nasal and sinus cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/nasal-and-sinus-cancer/)
- Nasopharyngeal cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/nasopharyngeal-cancer/) – affects the part of the throat connecting the back of the nose to the back of the mouth
- Retinoblastoma (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/retinoblastoma/) – a type of eye cancer that affects children
- Thyroid cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/thyroid-cancer/) – affects the small gland at the front, lower part of your neck (thyroid) that releases hormones

Genitals and reproductive system

- Cervical cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/cervical-cancer/)
- Ovarian cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/ovarian-cancer/)
- Penile cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/penile-cancer/)
- Prostate cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/prostate-cancer/)
- Testicular cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/testicular-cancer/)
- Vaginal cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/vaginal-cancer/)
- Vulval cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/vulval-cancer/)
- Womb cancer (uterus or endometrial cancer) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/womb-cancer/)

Skin

- Melanoma skin cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/melanoma-skin-cancer/) – less common and usually more serious than non-melanoma skin cancer
- Non-melanoma skin cancer (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/non-melanoma-skin-cancer/) – more common and usually less serious than melanoma skin cancer

Other parts of the body

- Hodgkin lymphoma (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/hodgkin-lymphoma/) – affects the lymph system (part of the body's immune system)
- Mesothelioma (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/mesothelioma/) – affects the lining that covers some of the body's organs
- Non-Hodgkin lymphoma (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/non-hodgkin-lymphoma/) – affects the lymph system (part of the body's immune system)
- Soft tissue sarcoma (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/soft-tissue-sarcoma/) – affects the tissues that connect and support other organs and parts of the body

Find out more

Cancer charities have more information about these and other types of cancer:

- Cancer Research UK: your cancer type (Link: <https://www.cancerresearchuk.org/about-cancer/type>)
- Macmillan Cancer Support: cancer types A to Z (Link: <https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/cancer-types>)

Common treatments for cancer

The treatment you'll have depends on the type of cancer.

The most common treatments for cancer include:

- surgery to remove the cancer
- chemotherapy (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/chemotherapy/), which uses medicines to kill cancer cells
- radiotherapy (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/radiotherapy/), which uses radiation to kill cancer cells

Treatment can also involve:

- immunotherapy, where medicines are used to help your immune system kill cancer
- hormone therapy to help stop or slow down the growth of cancer

You'll be looked after by a team of specialists who will work with you to create a treatment plan that is best for you.

Cancer waiting times

The NHS aims to diagnose and treat cancer as early as possible. NHS England has guidance on cancer waiting times for being diagnosed and starting treatment.

The guidance says:

- if you get an urgent referral to a specialist, cancer should be confirmed or ruled out within 28 days of the referral
- if you're diagnosed with cancer, treatment should start within 31 days of the diagnosis or within 62 days of an urgent referral

Support while you wait

Macmillan Cancer Support has a free helpline open every day from 8am to 8pm.

They're there to listen if you have anything you want to talk about.

Call 0808 808 00 00

More information

National cancer charities offering support and information about cancer, including the symptoms, types, causes and treatments:

- Macmillan Cancer Support (Link: <http://www.macmillan.org.uk/>)
- Cancer Research UK (Link: <http://www.cancerresearchuk.org/>)
- Cancer waiting times: NHS England (Link: <https://www.england.nhs.uk/statistics/statistical-work-areas/cancer-waiting-times/>)

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